THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

ACT ONE

Written by

[Writer]

From the Development Bible, Revision 2 (Beats 1-9)
First draft of Act One. The feature continues in Act Two.
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FADE IN:

BLACK.

The sound of rain on a slate roof. Not a drumming: a thousand small clicks, like typing heard through a wall.

SUPER: "AUGUST 14, 1987"

INT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

CLOSE ON A PENCIL, moving.

A BOY'S HAND holds it, pale as paper, a smudge of graphite along the edge of the palm. The page is in a green cloth notebook. On the cover, in careful capitals: THE MARGIN. Beneath, smaller: BY THEODORE LINDQVIST. PRIVATE.

The words arrive as he writes them, round and neat, a little too carefully spaced:

> *Behind the pond there is a door. Behind the door is the back of everything. Whatever is lost goes there. Whatever is forgotten waits.*

The pencil hovers. Starts again:

> *Theodore put his ear to the door and*

A kitchen the color of weak tea. Yellow linoleum. A table scarred with a century of ring marks. A round white school clock over the back door: 3:05. On the counter, a plastic RADIO, turned low.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)
...five past three on a wet Friday, you're with Rutland's own WRUT, and if you were thinking of a picnic, don't.

We never see the boy's face. Only the hand, the back of an untidy head, a shoulder bent over the table like a grown man's.

Behind him a SCREEN DOOR opens on a long complaint of spring. Bare feet on linoleum. Small, wet slaps.

NELL (O.S.)
(five)
Theo?

The pencil doesn't stop.

NELL (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Will you come see the door?

THEO (9)
(not looking up)
In a minute.

NELL (O.S.)
You said after lunch.

THEO (9)
I know. In a minute.

A pause. A small one.

NELL (O.S.)
Okay.

No complaint in it. Only trust.

The screen door sighs shut.

The pencil moves. Rain on slate. The page fills.

Outside, the rain thins. The clicks on the roof slow, spread out, stop. In the silence the radio is suddenly very loud.

RADIO DJ (V.O.)
...looks like it's clearing over the valley. Twenty-six minutes past three.

The pencil reaches the end of a line. Stops.

The boy sits back. Flexes his fingers. Looks up.

HIS POV: the kitchen. Empty.

The back door stands an inch open. And across the yellow linoleum, from the screen door to his chair and out again, TWO SETS of small bare footprints, wet and gleaming. In. And out, the second set evenly spaced. Unhurried. The prints of a child who has been told "in a minute" and has decided to go ahead.

THEO (9)
(not yet afraid)
Nell?

Nothing. Water ticks from the eaves.

A single DROP of water lands on the open page. It falls from directly above the camera, from nowhere, and the pencil lines run, soft and gray, until the last sentence is a bruise.

SMASH TO BLACK.

THE GHOSTWRITER FROM THE 6TH DIMENSION

SUPER: "THIRTY-EIGHT YEARS LATER"

INT. STATION WAGON - MOVING - DAY

Rain on a car roof. The same small clicks.

A ten-year-old station wagon packed to the headliner. Cardboard boxes in a precise woman's handwriting: JUNE - SCHOOL. JUNE - OTHER. THEO - BOOKS (DON'T). A cooler of things nobody will eat.

At the wheel, THEO LINDQVIST (47): tall, stooped, handsome in a worn way. A good coat and a bad night's sleep. Long pale hands that are never still. Right now they tap the steering wheel in a rhythm that's almost typing.

Beside him, JUNE (12): a hoodie two sizes up, a laptop open on her knees, and the habit of looking at everything, weather, strangers, her father, the way other kids look at screens.

The radio is public radio, the volume low, the HOST warm as a cardigan.

HOST (V.O.)
...from our archive. The winter Theo Lindqvist's debut, "Slate," won everything it was eligible for. It opens on a boy at a kitchen table while, across the valley, something terrible is happening. And he doesn't know. And then he does. Did you have that afternoon?

THEO (ON RADIO)
(thirty-two, smiling)
I was home. I was nine, I was writing at the kitchen table, and I felt it. You know how you can feel a door open somewhere in a house? I felt it in the kitchen. I didn't know what I'd felt until they came home.

Theo's hand drifts to the dial. June gets there first and turns it UP.

HOST (V.O.)
You've said you don't write your books. You take dictation.

THEO (ON RADIO)
I just try to be in the room when they arrive.

HOST (V.O.)
And if they don't?

THEO (ON RADIO)
(an easy laugh)
They always arrive.

June turns it off.

JUNE
You sound like you're about to win something.

THEO
I did win something.

JUNE
That's what I mean.

JUNE (CONT'D)
So what happens when they don't?

THEO
When what doesn't?

JUNE
Arrive.

THEO
(the smile arriving late)
Your mother's been talking.

JUNE
Mom says you've been "between books" since I was four.

THEO
Your mother is very gifted at euphemism.

JUNE
It's not a euphemism. It's a quote.

The dash lights up: PRIYA RAMAN - EDITOR. Theo watches it the way you watch weather. It stops. A beat later: ONE NEW VOICEMAIL. June leans over and taps PLAY.

THEO
June.

JUNE
It's a public car.

PRIYA (V.O.)
(brisk, fond, furious)
Theo, it's Priya. I'm not calling about the deadline. (beat) I'm calling about the deadline. December first. Legal has started saying the word "advance" in a tone. I don't need a book. I need pages. Not a feeling about pages. Call me. I love you. Call me.

Click. June closes the voicemail with one finger, tidily.

JUNE
Mom bet me ten dollars you'd say it before Albany. I took Saratoga.

THEO
Say what?

JUNE
(letting it go)
Never mind.
(turning the laptop toward him)
It's eleven pages. It's a crossover. You wouldn't know either show. Will you read it?

Theo's eyes stay on the road. His hands, for once, are still.

THEO
In a minute.

June watches him. Then she closes the laptop, slowly, with both hands, like shutting a book on a pressed flower.

JUNE
(to the window)
We're past Saratoga.

It is the face of a girl who has just won ten dollars and would give it back.

The road bends along the lip of a quarry. Through the rain: a stepped gash in the hillside, shelf after shelf of gray slate going down, and at the bottom a pond. Flat. Black. The rain is falling on it, you can see it falling, but the surface doesn't mark.

A gravel turnout. A slab of granite, plastic flowers bleached white, and a jar of fresh marigolds, bright as a struck match. Someone keeps it.

June cranes around as it slides past.

JUNE (CONT'D)
(reading)
"Tomas Arvidsen. Nineteen seventy-four to nineteen eighty-seven. He reached for her."
(turning back)
Who's Tomas Arvidsen?

THEO
(very even)
A boy who lived down the road.

JUNE
He was thirteen.

THEO
He pulled my sister out of that pond. He didn't come out himself.

JUNE
Aunt Nell.

THEO
Yes.

JUNE
Are we stopping?

THEO
No.

JUNE
(a beat)
Okay.

The marker shrinks in the mirror and the bend takes it. Theo's hands have found the wheel again. They are tapping.

EXT. LINDQVIST FARMHOUSE - DAY

The top of a gravel lane. A white clapboard farmhouse gone the gray of old teeth, under a roof of gray slate. Past the field, the quarry's rim: a flat dark line against the sky. A FOR SALE sign leans against the porch rail, not yet staked.

The wagon crunches up and stops. Neither of them moves.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

The door opens on the smell: cold ash, lemon polish, wet stone.

Dust sheets over the furniture, ghosts in a waiting room: the house of a woman who stopped being able to change things, and so didn't.

The kitchen is the kitchen from 1987. Same yellow linoleum, same scarred table, same round white clock over the back door, same plastic radio on the counter. Thirty-eight years of dust; not one object moved.

Theo stands in the doorway and doesn't come in.

June goes in ahead of him, the way kids do, as if the house were a pool.

JUNE
Smells like a library that died.

THEO
Your grandmother was a librarian.

JUNE
Then it's accurate.

She opens the refrigerator. Closes it quickly.

JUNE (CONT'D)
There's a jar of something that used to be a pickle.

On the refrigerator door, a photograph held by a magnet shaped like a lobster. A BOY OF NINE, unmistakably Theo, all elbows and hair, squinting into the sun. Beside him a much taller boy straddles a bicycle in a red jacket, freckled hands on the handlebars. The lobster sits squarely on the taller boy's face.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Who's that?

THEO
Me.

JUNE
The other one.

THEO
(a beat too long)
A neighbor.

June reaches for the magnet.

THEO (CONT'D)
Go find a bed.

JUNE
Which one's yours?

THEO
Top of the stairs. On the left.

She goes. He lets out a breath he didn't know he was holding.

INT. FARMHOUSE - HALL - DAY

A long, narrow ground-floor hall running the length of the house, floorboards worn to a dip down the middle. Coat pegs. On the right, an arch into the sitting room, where a heavy wood-cabinet television sits with its screen gone dark.

June, hoodie sleeves over her hands, walks it like a path in a story.

Halfway down on the left, a door that sits deeper in its frame than the others. An inch, no more, as if the house has been holding something back with its shoulder. A faded card is thumbtacked to it: CELLAR.

June looks at it. Theo, in the kitchen doorway behind her, doesn't.

At the far end of the hall, a last door. Painted white, and painted again, and again, so many coats that the seam has closed over like a scar.

June tries the knob. It turns. The door doesn't.

JUNE
It's painted shut.

THEO
(from the kitchen)
It's cold-weather storage.

JUNE
Whose room was it?

THEO
Storage, June.

JUNE
That's not a whose.

THEO
(a smile with nothing behind it)
Nobody's. Go on up.

June studies him. Studies the door. She lets go of the knob, and as she does, very faintly, from the other side of the paint, something settles. A board giving up its weight.

She doesn't hear it. We do.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

One lamp. The refrigerator hums. Theo at the table with a legal pad, a mug of tea going cold, a good pen.

He does what he has always done. Rests the pen on the first line. Closes his eyes. Breathes the way you breathe before a dive.

And waits.

A ritual with a long record of success. Nothing. He waits longer. The refrigerator cycles off. The silence is large and specific.

Eyes open. The page is exactly as blank as he left it. He writes "It was." Looks at it. Crosses it out.

Under the silence, behind it, like a tenant in the wall, another sound.

A pencil.

Not here. Not on his page. The faint dry rasp of graphite on paper, steady, unhurried, a few feet away and impossibly close. It's coming from inside the wall behind the stove.

Theo stops breathing. Crosses to the wall. Puts his ear to the plaster.

The scratch moves along the wall, slow as a sentence, toward the hall. He follows it three steps. Stops. It stops.

He waits. It waits.

THEO
(to the wall, absurdly polite)
...Hello?

Nothing. A pipe knocks somewhere. He laughs at himself, a small tired sound, and goes back to the table.

He sits. Closes his eyes again.

The pencil starts again, softer, in time with his own breathing, and Theo finds it, to his own alarm, restful.

His head goes down on his arm.

A floorboard. JUNE at the foot of the stairs in socks and an enormous T-shirt, a glass of water in her hand. She looks at her father asleep at the table, the blank pad beside his arm.

She takes his coat from the back of the chair and lays it over his shoulders. Then, after a moment, she tears a corner from the pad, writes on it, and tucks it under his mug.

INSERT - THE SCRAP, in a twelve-year-old's slanting hand:

DAD - 11 PAGES. WHENEVER. -J.

She looks at it. Adds a smiley face. Crosses out the smiley face. Goes.

In the wall, the pencil keeps going. Softly. Under the hum.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - MORNING

Gray light. Birds. Theo wakes with the print of his sleeve on his cheek and a crick in his neck.

On the pad, squared to its edges as if laid there by a careful hand, a single sheet of paper.

Not legal-pad yellow. Cream. Ruled in faded green. A deckle edge. The kind of paper that stopped being made before he could drive.

It's covered in handwriting. A child's. Round, upright, careful. Brown-black ink that still shines.

He doesn't touch it. He reads, lips barely moving:

The slate was cold on my teeth.
That is the first thing. I want to tell it in order.
It was Friday and it was raining and the kitchen smelled like wet stone. I was writing. Nell asked me to come see the door and I said in a minute.
I did not look up.

His face does nothing. His face has had a long time to learn how.

He touches the page. It's DAMP. He lifts his fingertips to his nose: wet stone. Pond water.

He looks at the letters. The crossbars on the t's float above the stems, never quite touching. He hasn't made a t like that since fifth grade, when Mrs. Hartley told him it looked like a mistake.

It is his handwriting. The one he had at nine.

He is on his feet. The back door: bolted from the inside. The windows: latched. The front door: chained. He comes back to the table breathing through his nose.

Under his mug, June's scrap: DAD - 11 PAGES. WHENEVER. -J.

Something crosses his face and is put away.

JUNE (O.S.)
What?

June in the doorway with a cereal box, hair in a shape.

THEO
(too light)
Did you write this?

He holds out the page. She comes closer. Reads. Her mouth moves slightly on the last line.

JUNE
That's not me. I write like I'm twelve, not nine.

THEO
It isn't a joke, June.

JUNE
I know it isn't. You went white.

She looks at the page again. At him.

JUNE (CONT'D)
Is it from your book?

THEO
No.

JUNE
Then who...

THEO
(honestly)
I don't know.

It is the first plain thing he has said to her all day, and it frightens them both.

He turns the page over. The paper has buckled, as if soaked from the other side. Ghosts of the same lines show through backward, bled and pale. He tilts it to the window. The mirror-writing swims. He doesn't try to read it.

THEO (CONT'D)
Bleed-through.

Nobody asked.

He looks around for somewhere to put it. Finds nothing. Slides it into the nearest book: his own debut, a paperback with a prize sticker on the spine, on a shelf of his mother's treasures. All three of his novels, spines aligned, the way she's kept them. He stands with his palm flat against them like a man steadying a ship.

INT. ALDER HILL MEMORY CARE - DAYROOM - DAY

A low brick building, a garden of bird feeders. Beside each resident's door a shadow box: a photograph, a thimble, a wedding program, so they can find their way home.

The dayroom: tall windows onto a gray garden. A jigsaw puzzle half finished. A man at the window standing the way you stand at a bus stop. Two women at a table matching socks.

At the corner table, INGRID LINDQVIST (79): small, upright, white braid pinned like a crown, cardigan buttoned one hole off. She is folding washcloths with a librarian's precision. A basin of water at her elbow. She dips each cloth, wrings it, folds it in thirds, lays it on a stack, and counts under her breath.

INGRID
One in. Two in.

Theo stops in the doorway, June at his shoulder.

THEO
Mom.

Ingrid looks up. Her whole face opens, pure unguarded delight, a woman seeing the person she most wants to see.

INGRID
Tomas! Look at you.

She looks him up and down, a mother's inspection, head to foot.

INGRID (CONT'D)
You'll catch your death.

THEO
(gently)
It's Theo, Mom.

A flicker. The librarian surfaces: exact, a little irritated, a woman correcting a catalog.

INGRID
Theo's at the table. Theo's writing.

THEO
(a small, bleak smile)
Some things.

INGRID
(to herself, folding)
Tomas came back wet. Theo came back dry. I counted them both in.

She lays a washcloth on the stack.

INGRID (CONT'D)
One in. Two in.

Behind Theo (he is facing his mother; he can't see it) the dayroom RESIDENTS lift their heads at the word "wet." Together. The man at the window. The women with the socks. A woman in the doorway with a walker. They all turn the same way, toward the glass doors at the end of the corridor and the gray garden beyond.

Then, together, they turn back.

Only June sees. She looks at the faces. She looks at her father's back. She says nothing.

INGRID (CONT'D)
(to June, bright)
And who's this?

JUNE
I'm June.

INGRID
You look like the other librarian.

JUNE
My mom's a conservator.

INGRID
That's what I said.

June, startled into a real smile.

A NURSE comes through with a medication cart: ELLIE (43). Practical hair, reading glasses on a chain, a pale band on her bare ring finger. Her badge: ELLIE M., RN.

From Theo's side of the table Ellie is slightly soft: not blurred, just never quite sharp, as if the lens won't settle on her. When he looks away, when we do, she is as clear as a photograph.

ELLIE
Afternoon meds, Mrs. L.

INGRID
(radiant, conspiratorial)
She's always on time.

THEO
(to Ellie's name tag)
I thought the night nurse was...

ELLIE
Covering. Somebody called out.

THEO
Thank you. For all of this.

ELLIE
It's the job.

His eyes slide off her. Find the med cart, the window, the stack of washcloths. Everywhere but her face.

INGRID
(watching them, quietly, to Ellie)
He doesn't see you, does he.

A very small pause.

ELLIE
(pleasantly)
She's tired, Mr. Lindqvist.

THEO
Of course.

Theo doesn't hear it.

INT. ALDER HILL - NURSES' STATION - DAY

DR. HASKELL (50s): kind, tired, a man who has said these sentences before.

DR. HASKELL
She still has windows. They're getting shorter.

THEO
How long?

DR. HASKELL
Months. Maybe less. The steps down come without warning.

THEO
And the permanent wing?

DR. HASKELL
The business office will talk to you. I'd start soon.

THEO
We're selling the house.

EXT. ALDER HILL - PARKING LOT - DAY

Mist now, instead of rain. Theo fumbles his keys. June stays on her side of the car.

JUNE
She counted two.

THEO
Two what?

JUNE
You and the other one. Every time. "One in. Two in."

THEO
She was folding washcloths.

JUNE
She said "both."

Theo opens the car door. Doesn't have an answer. Doesn't look for one.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN / HALL - NIGHT

The house asleep. The refrigerator hums.

(ONE UNBROKEN SHOT. The camera is set low at the kitchen doorway, looking down the length of the hall. It does not move.)

Theo enters frame from the kitchen in socks, a mug in his hand, and stops. He has heard something. A drip. One. Then, a long beat later, another.

He walks away from us down the hall, past the dust-sheeted arch of the sitting room, to the cellar door on the left. Stands before it.

Drip.

He lays his palm flat on the wood. Listens. The door sits deeper in its frame than it should, and in the dim hall light his hand looks very small against it.

THEO
(low)
Pipes.

He takes his hand away. Turns. Walks back toward us, down the hall, and the drip stops.

Behind him, at the foot of the cellar door, a footprint appears.

Bare. Narrow. Long, too long for a child. It simply is, on the dry boards, as if pressed into a sponge: water welling up into the shape of a heel, a ball, five toes.

Theo walks on. Twelve feet. Ten.

A second print, a stride beyond the first. Then a third. They arrive one at a time, each half a second after the last, down the hall and away from us, toward the far end. Unhurried. Someone walking. Someone we can't see, going the other way, passing Theo in the dark as if he weren't there.

Theo reaches the kitchen doorway and steps out of frame, left.

The camera stays. The prints keep coming. Down the hall to the last door, the painted one, where the final print lands and a thin dark line of water begins to spread beneath it, along the seam, into the room that isn't storage.

A long beat. The house breathes. Under the floor: the soft rasp of a pencil.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Theo at the counter, reaching for the milk. His hand stops. The silence is wrong.

He comes back to the doorway. Looks down the hall.

THEO
(barely)
No.

The hall light is on. The prints are bright in it.

He walks them. Crouches over the first. Touches it. Cold. Brings his fingers to his nose: wet stone. Pond.

He looks down at his own socks. Dry.

He follows the prints to the end. Stands before the painted door. A dark line spreads beneath it and does not stop. He puts his hand on the knob. It is wet.

He takes his hand away. Stands there a long time.

Then he does the most human thing available. He gets a mop.

He mops the hall. Fast, hard, the way you hide something from yourself. The boards darken and dry. At the painted door he mops longest.

INT. FARMHOUSE - SITTING ROOM - NIGHT

The old television in its wood cabinet, screen dead, dusty, black as a pond. In its glass, a dim reflection of the hall.

Theo, small in the glass, at the light switch. He lets out a breath. His hand rises to the switch.

BEHIND HIM in the reflection, at the far end of the hall by the painted door, something stands. Tall. Narrow. Dripping.

THREE FRAMES.

Click. The hall goes dark. The glass is black.

Under the floor, one long stroke of a pencil.

Then nothing.

INT. SLATE DINER - MORNING

A long narrow room with a counter, six booths, and a framed photograph of the quarry in 1952: men in caps standing on a

shelf of slate like gods on a staircase. Every regular has a mug in front of him like a flag.

Theo and June at the counter. June is dismantling a stack of pancakes with surgical detachment. Theo has coffee and a legal pad with nothing on it. DONNA (60s), the waitress, tops him off without asking.

DONNA
You're Ingrid's boy.

THEO
I am.

DONNA
I was sorry to hear about your mother.

THEO
Thank you. She's not... she isn't gone.

DONNA
No. I know. It's just the word we've got.

A stool scrapes.

WALTER PRUITT (74) settles one stool down: tweed jacket, hearing aid, impeccable manners, and the air of a man who has spent his life standing half a step behind other people. He orders without opening a menu.

WALTER
(to Theo, rueful)
Forgive me. You're Theo Lindqvist.

THEO
Depends who's asking.

WALTER
Nobody important. Walter Pruitt. Quarry Road, three doors past you. I've read "Slate" twice, which is once more than I read most of what I wrote.

THEO
You're a writer.

WALTER
I was a ghostwriter. It's different. A writer wants to be read. A ghost wants to be believed.

JUNE
(looking up from the pancakes)
What's a ghostwriter?

WALTER
Someone who writes the book you think someone else wrote. Forty-one of them, in my case. Senators. Quarterbacks. A woman who'd been married to three of the four men she says she met in Paris. Not a name on one of them. That's the job. You vanish into somebody's voice.

JUNE
That's the saddest job I've ever heard.

WALTER
It has compensations. Nobody can ever blame you.

June glances at her father. Theo is looking into his coffee.

WALTER (CONT'D)
(lightly, stirring)
You're writing again. By hand.

THEO
I'm not writing.

WALTER
I heard it from my porch. Pencil. All night, from your house. A very particular sound. I used to dream in it.

THEO
I don't use a pencil.

A pause. Walter's spoon stops.

WALTER
No. I didn't think you did.

He sets down the spoon. Something in his courtliness has gone very careful.

WALTER (CONT'D)
If anyone offers to put a name on it, don't.

THEO
On what?

WALTER
Whatever it is you're not writing.

Theo stands to pay. Crosses to the register.

WALTER'S POV: behind Theo, across the clean dry linoleum, WET FOOTPRINTS appear. Bare. Long. One after another, a pace behind him, following him down the length of the diner. Nobody looks down. Donna rings up the coffee. A man turns a page of his newspaper through them.

Walter's cup rattles in its saucer. He sets it down with both hands.

WALTER (CONT'D)
(barely audible, to no one)
Oh, you poor boy.

He could mean Theo. He could mean the thing behind him. The prints reach the register and stop, beside Theo, close as a hand on his sleeve.

EXT. FARMHOUSE LANE - DAY

Afternoon, the light thin and rinsed. Theo walks down the gravel lane to the mailbox, a rusted tin loaf on a post, to see whether the world has sent him anything but bills.

It has. A utility bill. A realtor's flyer. And an envelope, cream, DAMP. No stamp. No postmark. On the front, in a child's round hand:

Theodore

He stands very still. He says it aloud, once, to hear how it sounds. It sounds like someone else's coat.

The lane is empty to the bend.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Theo at the table, the envelope open, two sheets of cream ledger paper spread before him. The same hand. The same shining brown-black ink. He reads. A BOY'S VOICE reads with him, young, dry, careful, not quite his own.

BOY (V.O.)
Nell was in her yellow dress, the one with the ducks. Mom said not to wear it to the quarry. Mom said a lot of things.

EXT. QUARRY - DAY (FLASHBACK, 1987)

16mm. Warm. Honeyed. Sun on wet slate, steaming. A world seen through a window of amber.

A small girl in a yellow dress printed with ducks, all the ducks facing the same way as if they knew where they were going, seen from behind on a ledge above a flat black pond. Her face is turned away.

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
The rain had stopped and the slate was steaming and everything smelled like wet pennies. The pond was perfectly flat. It had no sky in it. I remember thinking that was wrong, and then I remember I didn't think anything, because she wasn't on the ledge anymore.

The yellow dress is gone. Where she stood, a ring spreading on the water.

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
That's how it happens. You don't see it. You see that she was there, and now she isn't.

HANDS wade into the pond: a boy's, long-fingered, freckled across the knuckles. On the ledge behind them, a red jacket lies where it was dropped.

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I went in. I didn't decide to. The cold came up my legs like a hand. It tasted of iron. It tasted like a coin you've held in your mouth all day.

UNDERWATER. Green-black. Sunlight in broken coins overhead. The yellow dress, sinking. The freckled hands close on it and come away with only water.

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I had her. I had her under the arms and then I didn't. She went out of my hands like something dropped in a well.

THE LEDGE, from below, through the surface: a bright wavering rectangle of sky. Empty.

BOY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
I looked up at the ledge for someone to call. There was nobody on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down. I looked.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - DAY

Theo has stopped. The last line he's read hangs in the air of the room. Something twitches at the corner of his eye, the way a muscle does before it remembers.

He runs a finger down the page as if looking for a name. There is no name. There is no boy on the ledge. There is no one but the voice and the water.

His phone buzzes on the table. ALDER HILL.

ELLIE (V.O.)
(through the phone)
Mr. Lindqvist? It's Ellie, from the home. Your mother's asking for you. She's having a window. I thought you'd want to know.

THEO
I'll be right there.

He gathers the pages without looking at them and folds them into his coat.

INT. ALDER HILL - INGRID'S ROOM - EVENING

Low gold light through a window onto the garden. A narrow bed. A shadow box beside the door: Gunnar in his quarry cap; Ingrid at a library desk, thirty years younger; Theo's three book jackets, cropped. One square of the felt backing is paler than the rest, as if something had hung there once.

Ingrid sits by the window, upright, hands folded. And she is, it's visible at once, HERE. Her eyes have focus. Her mouth has its old firmness.

INGRID
Theo.
(looking at him properly, a little rueful)
You look dreadful. Are you sleeping?

THEO
(a half laugh, relief breaking)
Not especially.

INGRID
You never did.

He sits. Takes her hand. It is dry, papery, warm.

THEO
Mom, I need to ask you something.
It's about Nell.

Her fingers tighten, very slightly.

THEO (CONT'D)
Do you remember her yellow dress?
The one with the ducks?

Silence. The light in the window goes on gilding the garden.

INGRID
(quietly)
Where did you get that?

THEO
I read it somewhere. It's just a...

INGRID
Who told you about the ducks?

THEO
Nobody told me. It was on a page.
Someone wrote it down.

Her grip closes on his wrist like a trap. Her hand is suddenly, impossibly COLD, and WET: water beading from her cuff, running down her forearm, dropping from her elbow to the floor in slow, heavy drops.

THEO (CONT'D)
Mom...

INGRID
You weren't there.

THEO
(a whisper)
It says I was. It says I went in the water.

INGRID
You weren't there. You were never there. Your father...

She stops. Her eyes slide off something just over his shoulder. The firmness in her mouth loosens, as if a hand has let go of it.

INGRID (CONT'D)
(politely, to a stranger)
Are you the man about the piano?

Ellie is in the doorway with a towel already in her hand. She crosses quickly and kneels, working Ingrid's fingers off Theo's wrist one at a time.

ELLIE
Okay, Mrs. L. Okay. I've got you.

Theo's wrist wears a wet ring like a bracelet. Water runs into his cuff. Under Ingrid's chair a dark puddle is spreading across the clean floor.

Ellie sees it. Looks at the puddle for exactly one second. At Theo's wrist. At Ingrid's dry-eyed, vacant face. Her own face (sharp, clear, for us) goes very still, like a woman who has smelled something from her childhood.

Theo looks at her and, again, can't hold her. He looks at the towel instead.

ELLIE (CONT'D)
(for him; evenly)
She's been at the sink again. She does that.

THEO
She said I wasn't there.

ELLIE
She says a lot of things.
(beat)
Let her rest, Mr. Lindqvist.

INT. FARMHOUSE - KITCHEN - NIGHT

11:38 by the round white clock. One lamp. The window over the sink is fogged from the kettle; beyond it, black.

Theo at the table. The three pages fanned before him like a hand of cards. The tea, again, cold. He has read them so often the words have begun to feel like furniture.

He says to the empty room:

THEO
I was home.

Nothing in the room contradicts him. Nothing agrees.

He picks up the third page.

He has always read every sentence he writes aloud, at night, to the empty house. It's the closest thing he has to prayer. He hasn't done it in eight years; there has been nothing to read.

THEO (CONT'D)
(quietly)
"I had her. I had her under the arms and then I didn't..."

His voice finds the cadence. Slows. His eyes close.

It's the old feeling. The sentence arrives a half-breath before he reads it, the way dictation used to come, as if the page isn't in front of him but inside him and he is only the one with the voice. A kind of joy comes into his face. It is the first time in eight years.

THEO (CONT'D)
"There was nobody on the ledge. I looked. I want that written down. I looked."

The clock ticks. 11:39.

THEO (CONT'D)
"There was nobody to take her hand."

His eyes open on the last line. His mouth has already begun it.

THEO (CONT'D)
"So I reached into the black water and took her hand, and..."

FLASH - THE POND, 16mm, amber: the freckled hands reach down through green-black water, through the broken coins of light, toward a small pale hand opening like a flower.

INT. KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

The clock's second hand STOPS. 11:40.

The refrigerator's hum cuts out. The kettle's last tick. Every sound in the house drops away but one: a single warm tone, low and sweet, like a wet finger on the rim of a glass.

The light changes. The lamp's yellow deepens to gold, an old painting's gold, and the kitchen is, for the first time, beautiful.

Theo opens his eyes.

In the dark window over the sink, his reflection. The kitchen in the glass is the same kitchen but warmer: gold-lit, the table scrubbed, the dust sheets gone. And the man at its table is Theo, but rested. Clean-shaven. Dry-haired. A man who has slept for years. He is smiling at Theo with a gentleness Theo has never worn.

Theo doesn't move. The reflection doesn't mimic him. It rises, half a beat, from the table in the glass and steps to the pane. Breathes on it. The glass fogs from the far side.

A fingertip draws, letter by letter, in a hand that matches the pages exactly:

Thank you

The letters read correctly. From the inside. For Theo.

The reflection holds his eyes. A look of enormous, tender gratitude, the look of a man thanking someone who has held a door.

In the lower corner of the pane, on the outside, the rain has smeared into a shape. Hand-sized. Splayed. As if someone had pressed a palm there, flat, and tried to be seen.

Theo does not see it. The reflection does. Its smile doesn't change.

The letters begin to run.

BLACK.

One stroke of a pencil.

END OF ACT ONE